

Data Centres, Social Media and Media Relations

WHY THIS MODULE MATTERS

AI now runs on physical infrastructure that is highly visible, energy-intensive and increasingly a matter of public interest. This module brings the whole course down to the data centre floor — including what every member of staff should do online and when approached by the media.

9.1 AI Workloads and the Modern Data Centre

Every framework in this course — ethics, failure analysis, governance, UK GDPR, implementation — ultimately has to run somewhere. Increasingly, that “somewhere” is a purpose-built data centre housing dense clusters of specialised processors, running AI training and inference workloads that draw far more power per rack than traditional enterprise IT. This module applies everything covered so far to that physical environment, and sets out the specific conduct expected of anyone working within it — including how to conduct yourself on social media and when approached by the press.

AI has changed the shape of demand on this sector in a short space of time. Training workloads are typically concentrated in large batches on high-density hardware; inference workloads are more distributed but constant. Both push power and cooling requirements far beyond what a legacy facility was designed for, which is why so much of the UK's current data centre construction and grid-connection activity is explicitly AI-driven.

9.2 Physical and Digital Security Convergence

Data centres have always required strong physical security. What has changed is that the systems enforcing that security — badge and biometric access control, CCTV analytics, visitor management — are themselves increasingly AI-enabled, which means they are subject to the same ethical and legal scrutiny as any other AI system covered in this course, not exempt from it because they sit in the security domain.

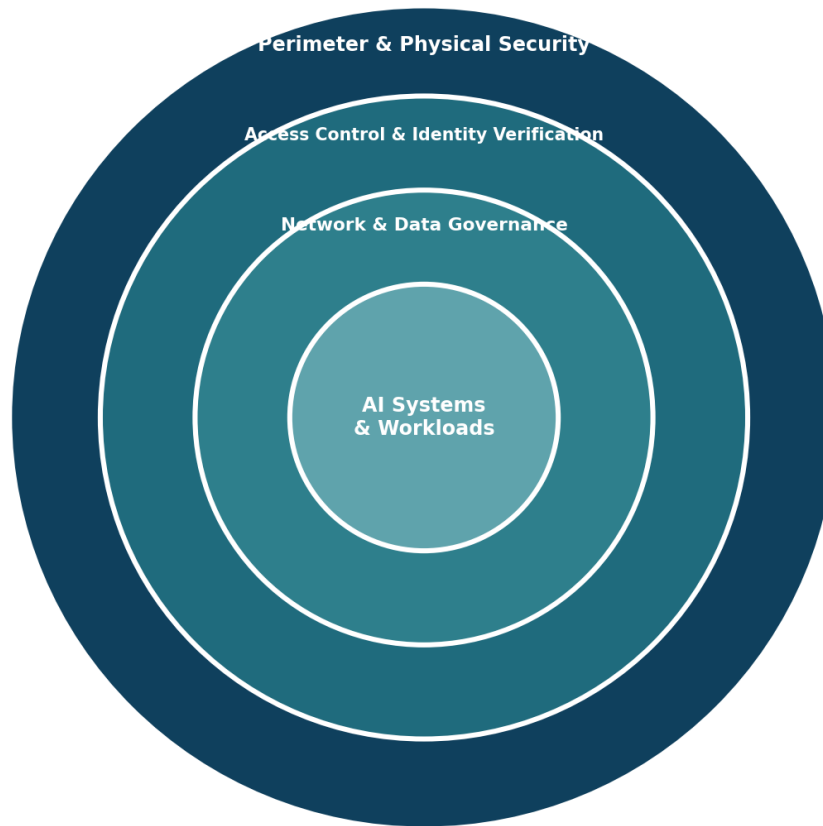


Figure 9.1 — Security and governance operate as layered controls, from the perimeter through to the AI workloads a data centre exists to run.

- **Perimeter and physical security** — fencing, vehicle control, security personnel; increasingly supported by AI-driven perimeter analytics that flag anomalies for human review.
- **Access control and identity verification** — biometric and badge systems governed by the Article 9 special category rules covered in Module 6, and by the fairness and accuracy concerns covered in Module 2.
- **Network and data governance** — the logical controls, covered throughout Modules 5 and 6, that determine who and what can reach a given client's data or workload.
- **AI systems and workloads** — the training and inference infrastructure that everything outside it exists to protect.

A security failure at any outer layer is potentially a data protection and AI governance failure at the centre, and vice versa — which is why this course treats physical security staff as core participants in AI governance,

not a separate function.

IN PRACTICE

A facilities team replaces keycard access with facial recognition at a data hall entrance to speed up shift changes. Before rollout, the AI Governance Committee requires evidence of accuracy testing across skin tones (Module 2), an Article 9 condition for the biometric data (Module 6), and a manual fallback for anyone the system fails to recognise — so a faster door never becomes a discriminatory one.

9.3 Sustainability and Energy Governance

AI-driven demand growth has made data centre energy and water use a matter of sustained UK public, political and media interest — from grid connection queues to local concerns about water used for cooling. This is not a peripheral issue for operational staff: it directly shapes planning permission conditions, community relations, and the kind of media attention covered later in this module.

- Operators over a certain size threshold have obligations under the UK's Streamlined Energy and Carbon Reporting (SECR) framework to report energy use and carbon emissions.
- Many larger sites operate under Climate Change Agreements, which set efficiency targets in exchange for a reduction in the Climate Change Levy.
- Local planning authorities increasingly attach specific conditions on power, water and noise, particularly in the high-density clusters around London and the Western Corridor.
- Grid connection delays, driven substantially by AI-related demand, have become a live national infrastructure story that operational staff may be asked about on site.

UK IN FOCUS

In September 2024, the UK Government designated data centres as Critical National Infrastructure (CNI) — the same protective category as the energy and water sectors. This raises baseline security expectations across the sector and means incidents affecting a qualifying facility can trigger a national, not just local or corporate, response.

9.4 Incident Response at the Data Centre

The governance structures from Module 5 — named ownership, defined escalation, monitoring — apply directly to data centre incident response, but the tempo is faster. A cooling fault, an unauthorised access attempt, or a protest at the perimeter fence can become a live incident within minutes, and staff on shift are usually the first to notice it, well before any central governance committee is convened.

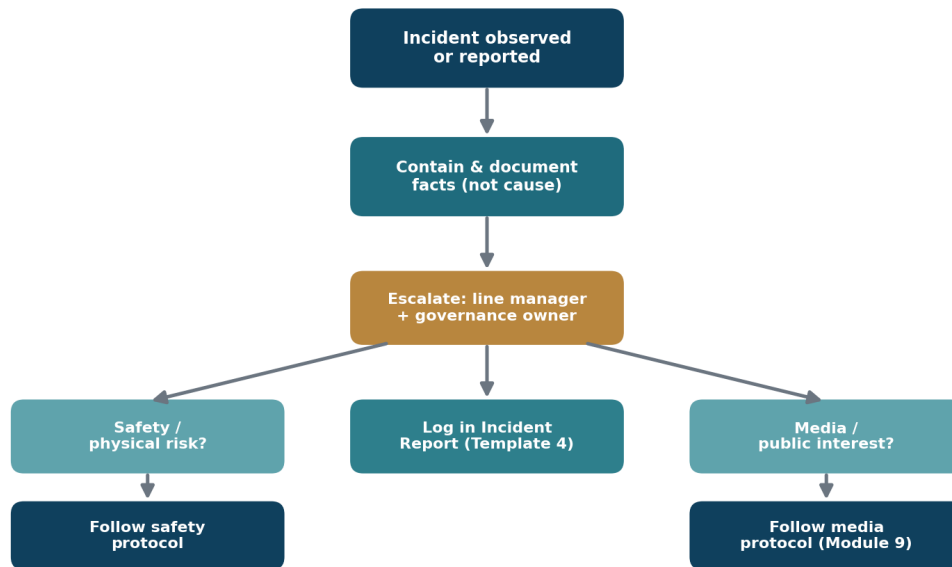


Figure 9.2 — The incident response workflow, connecting safety and media branches back to the same escalation and logging step.

- Know your site's incident escalation chain before you need it — who you call first, and what you are and are not authorised to say or do in the first five minutes.
- Treat security, safety and reputational incidents as connected, not separate — a physical security breach is very often also the start of a media and client-communications event.
- Document what you observed factually and promptly; do not speculate about cause in any written or verbal report while an incident is live.

TRY THIS — YOU ARE THE SITE DUTY MANAGER

Scenario: at 2am, a cooling unit alarm triggers in one data hall, and within ten minutes temperature in that hall has risen noticeably. Simultaneously, your security desk reports a small group has gathered at the perimeter fence with placards about the site's water use, and one is filming the gate on a phone. Do you: (a) focus entirely on the cooling fault and leave the perimeter to security; (b) treat both as one incident and escalate both simultaneously to your line manager and communications contact; (c) go to the fence yourself to ask the group to leave? (Model answer: (b). The two events may be unrelated, but a cooling fault filmed by protesters at the gate is a single reputational event in the making, not two separate ones — escalate both together immediately, following the media protocol below for the filming, and the incident escalation chain for the cooling fault, rather than triaging one and hoping the other resolves itself.)

9.5 Engaging with the Media: A Staff Protocol

Because they are highly visible, energy-intensive, security-sensitive and now classed as Critical National Infrastructure, UK data centres attract regular media interest — covering outages, security incidents, planning disputes, protests, and the environmental footprint of AI itself. Journalists sometimes approach sites directly, contact staff on social media, or speak to people at the perimeter, in car parks, or even outside work. Every member of staff, not only designated spokespeople, needs to know what to do when this happens.

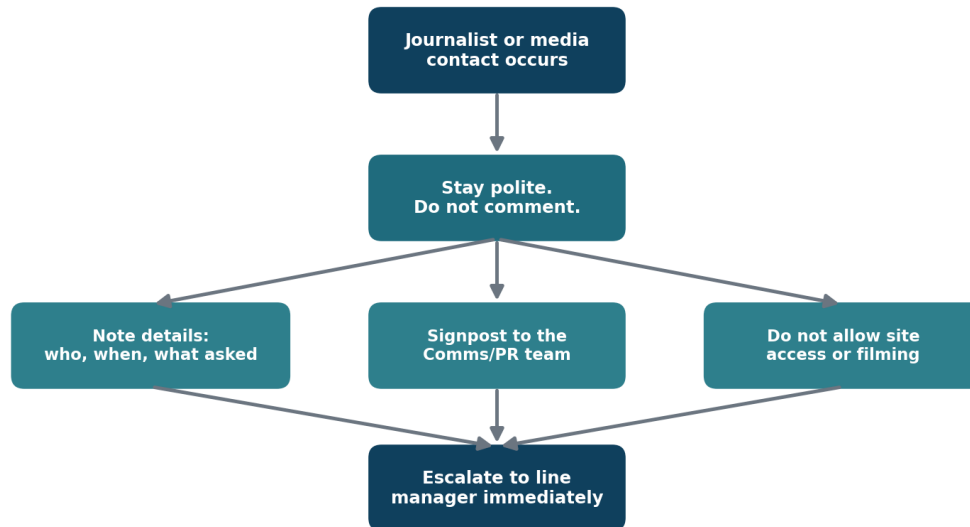


Figure 9.3 — The staff protocol for any unplanned media or journalist contact.

The Core Rule

No one other than a designated company spokesperson is authorised to speak to a journalist on behalf of the organisation — on the record, off the record, or “just as background”. This applies regardless of your seniority, how well you know the subject, or how informal the conversation feels. “Off the record” is not a reliable protection, and an informal comment can end up quoted, attributed, or used to piece together operational or client information that was never intended for publication.

What To Do, Step by Step

- Stay polite and calm.** Declining to comment is a normal, professional response, not a confrontation.
- Do not confirm or deny anything** about operations, clients, security posture, incidents, staffing levels, or capacity — even details that feel harmless in isolation.
- Do not let a journalist onto the site or into any restricted area**, even if they present a press card, and even if they claim to have prior permission — verify separately, through your own management, before any access is granted.
- Do not allow filming or photography** of the site, equipment, vehicles, badges or colleagues, and ask that any unauthorised filming stop.

- **Signpost, don't stonewall.** A simple, prepared line is enough: "I'm not able to comment — I can put you in touch with our communications team."
- **Take down the details** — the journalist's name, outlet, contact information, the time, and what they asked — as soon as it is safe and practical to do so.
- **Escalate immediately** to your line manager and the communications/PR team, even if the contact seemed minor or the journalist has since left.

A READY-MADE SCRIPT

"Thanks for reaching out — I'm not the right person to comment on that, and it's not something I'm able to discuss. I'd be glad to pass your details to our communications team so they can follow up with you directly. Could I take your name and contact details?" This line works for a phone call, a doorstep approach, or a message on social media, and commits you to nothing beyond a polite handover.

9.6 Posting About Work on Social Media

Most unplanned disclosures about a data centre do not come from a journalist doorstepping the gate — they come from a member of staff posting something innocuous-seeming online. A photo taken from a car park, a LinkedIn post celebrating a new role, a location check-in, or a complaint posted in frustration can each reveal a client relationship, a security layout, or an operational detail that the organisation, and often the client, never intended to make public.



Figure 9.4 — A quick personal checklist for posting about work on social media.

- **Never post photos, videos, or screen recordings** taken on site, including of equipment, badges, screens, dashboards, or colleagues, without explicit sign-off from communications.
- **Do not name or geotag a client or facility**, even in a job-change announcement — “new role in data centre operations” is safe; naming the specific site or client is not.
- **Treat a personal complaint the same as a media enquiry** — venting about a site issue online, even without naming it, can identify the facility to anyone who already knows where you work.
- **Review your own profile occasionally** — old posts, tagged photos, or a public location history can accumulate into a detailed picture over time, even if no single post seems risky.
- **Say something if you see it** — if a colleague, contractor, or visitor posts identifying content about the site, raise it with your line manager rather than commenting on the post itself.

This is not about restricting staff from having a normal online presence — it is about keeping the same boundary online that already exists in person: client identities and operational detail stay inside the organisation's own communications channels.

Many data centre staff, and staff placed by a recruitment agency, work under contractual confidentiality obligations covering client identities and site operations. Speaking to a journalist, or posting online, without authorisation, even with good intentions, can breach those obligations and carry disciplinary or contractual consequences — which is precisely why the escalation route above exists: it protects both the organisation and the individual member of staff.

TRY THIS — WHAT WOULD YOU DO?

You are on shift when someone identifying as a local journalist calls the site's main number asking to “just confirm” whether the facility lost power last night, since neighbours reported flickering streetlights. Using the protocol above, decide what you would say in the first ten seconds of that call, and what you would do in the five minutes after hanging up. (A model answer: give the ready-made script — decline to confirm or deny, offer to pass on their details — then immediately note the caller's name, outlet and question, and escalate to your line manager and communications team before doing anything else, even if the power event seems minor or already resolved.)

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- AI training and inference workloads are driving a step change in data centre power and cooling demand, which is why this sector now sits at the centre of the AI governance conversation.
- Physical security systems — biometric access, CCTV analytics — are AI systems in their own right and are governed by the same ethical and UK GDPR obligations as any other.
- UK data centres are designated Critical National Infrastructure, raising the baseline for security, incident response and public scrutiny.
- Only a designated spokesperson may speak to the media on the organisation's behalf — every other member of staff's role is to stay polite, say nothing substantive, note the details, and escalate immediately.
- The same discipline applies to personal social media — no client names, no site photos, no location tags, and no venting about work in ways that could identify the facility.
- Unauthorised comments to journalists or online posts can breach confidentiality obligations that protect both clients and the staff member themselves.

FURTHER READING

- gov.uk — announcement designating data centres as Critical National Infrastructure (September 2024)
- ICO — guidance on CCTV, workplace monitoring and biometric data
- National Grid ESO — connections guidance and grid capacity reporting

MODULE 9 CHECK-IN QUIZ

Five questions to confirm your understanding before moving on. Answers are provided in the Answer Key at the end of the course.

1. Why has AI specifically increased power and cooling demand in UK data centres?

- A. AI workloads use identical infrastructure to legacy enterprise IT
- B. Dense AI training and inference hardware draws far more power per rack than traditional IT
- C. AI systems do not require any physical infrastructure
- D. AI has reduced overall data centre demand

2. Why are biometric access control and CCTV analytics systems relevant to this course's governance framework?

- A. They are exempt from AI governance because they serve a security purpose
- B. They are AI systems in their own right and are subject to the same ethical and UK GDPR obligations as any other AI system
- C. They only process anonymous data
- D. They are regulated exclusively by the police

3. What status did the UK Government give data centres in September 2024?

- A. No formal status
- B. Critical National Infrastructure
- C. Temporary planning exemption
- D. Public sector body

4. According to the staff media protocol in Module 9, who is authorised to speak to a journalist on the organisation's behalf?

- A. Any member of staff who feels confident doing so
- B. Only a designated company spokesperson
- C. Whoever answers the phone first
- D. Security staff only

5. Under the social media guidance in Module 9, which of the following is acceptable to post?

- A. A geotagged photo of the data hall taken during a shift
- B. A LinkedIn post announcing a new role in data centre operations without naming the site or client
- C. A frustrated post about a work issue that indirectly identifies the facility
- D. A screenshot of an internal monitoring dashboard